

# BeThere

Taking the pain out of  
friend group meetups

DRP02 - Nelson Gong, Noah Seymour, Lukas Trakimas, James Hughff

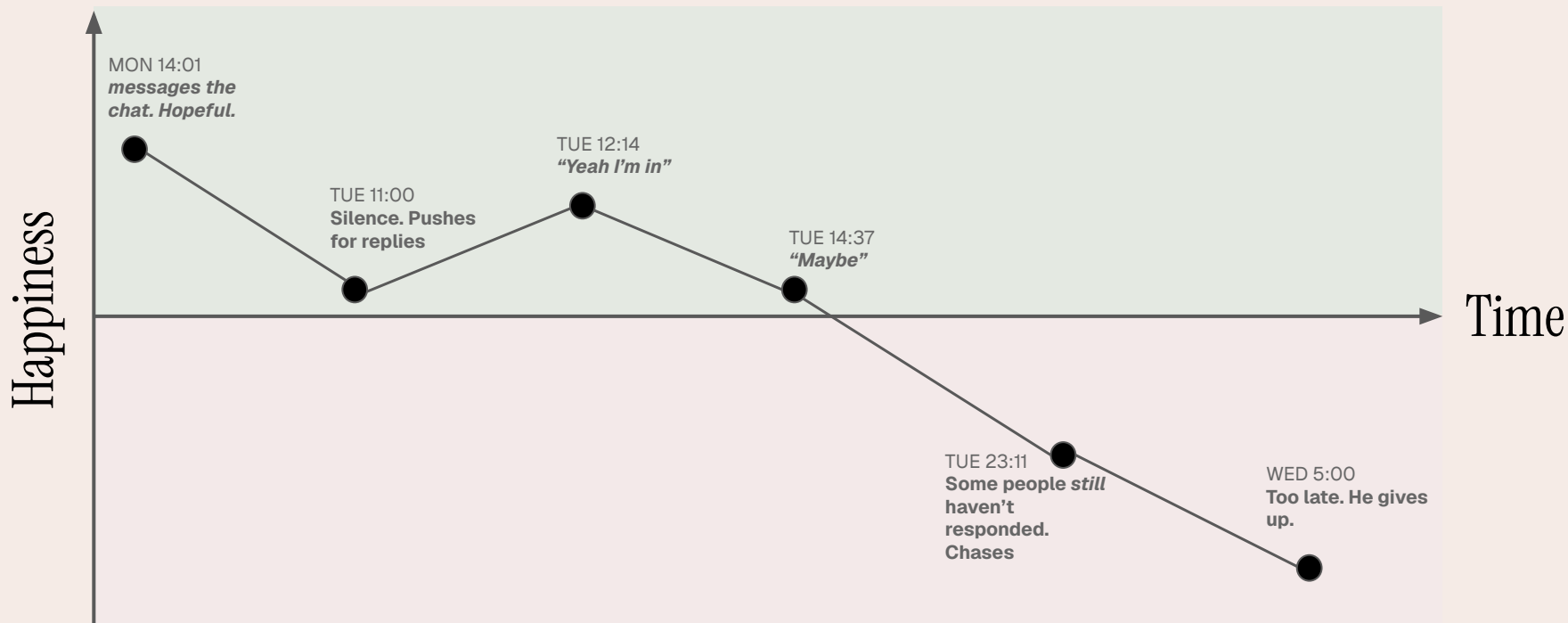
# Vasanth

- Age 21
- Studies Law at St. Andrews
- Enjoys playing volleyball and board games
- Loves to cook for his friends
- Extroverted and reliable

The **organiser**.



# Vasanth's Christmas break, mapped as he felt it.



**Vasanth loves to meet his friends, but organising is difficult and chasing replies from group members is frustrating**

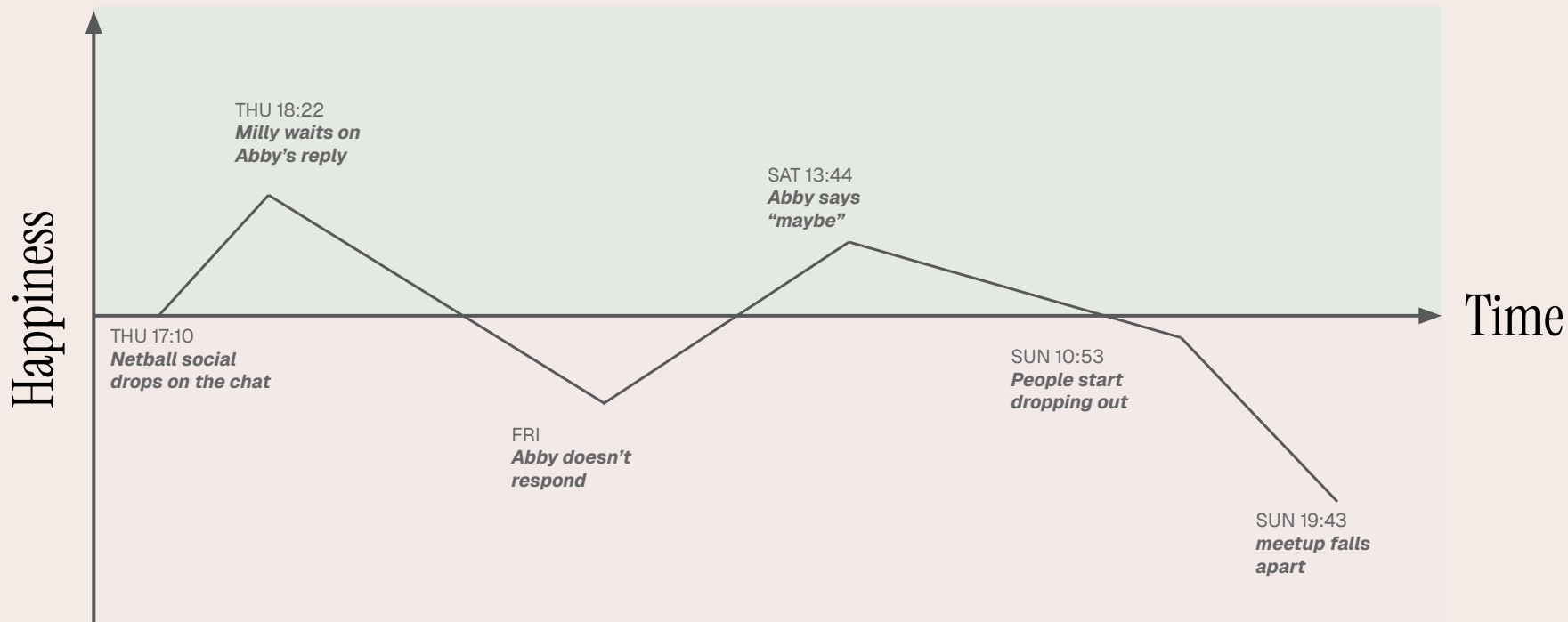
# Milly

- Age 19
- Studies English Literature at St. Andrews
- Likes to play cello and read
- Recently joined her university's netball society
- Shy and introverted

The passive participant



# Milly's netball social, mapped as she felt it.



Millie would love to engage with her netball society's socials more, but she is hesitant because she wants to be sure her friends are going too

To better understand this problem, we interviewed university students about their social lives.



*“If I drummed up the plan, and it's taken considerable time, looking at logistics, pricing, whether everyone's okay with it, and then it falls through after all of that, that's quite frustrating.”*

Eddie, 21, the *organiser*  
3rd year Psychology at Goldsmiths





*“As days went past, [the meetup] got more drawn out, second thoughts crept in, and more and more people ended up pulling out.”*

Chloe, 19, the *passive participant*  
2nd Year International Relations at King's College

*“If [I’m meeting] a friend of a friend,  
my attendance is conditional on my  
friend being there. I’ll wait for them to  
respond first, then decide.”*

Luca, 20, the passive participant  
BioChem at Oxford



# Two key stakeholder groups.

## 1. SUGGESTORS

One sided and exhausting. *Awkward*  
to push for replies.

## 2. PARTICIPANTS

Uncertainty *compounds* uncertainty.  
Some people's participation is  
*contingent* on others.

# 50%+

of our 47 survey respondents said **over a third** of meet-ups never made it out of the chat.

60%

said the meet-up time gets moved **half the time or more.**

# 87%

send a **maybe** or **delay** their response to a plan they are unsure about

a decade ago

7%

today

22%

*of young people have one or no close friends*



25%+

of lonely young people have sought therapy

*"How might we reduce **hesitancy** in university friend groups when planning to meet up so that groups go from frustrating '**maybe**' responses to a clear **consensus**?"*

Demonstration  
Suggesting a meetup

# User Story

**As a** social member of my friend group  
who tends to organise things  
**I want** to be able to easily suggest  
meetups to my friends  
**So that** I can see my friends more without  
the frustration of chasing responses



Core Interaction  
Simplify suggesting a meetup

# Our Initial Design

## Your meetups

T

1 ACTION REQUIRED

**climbing**  
Glitter Natters

VOTING CLOSES  
**21 hours left**

All

Going

Open

Done

**sky diving**  
Climbing Group

3 options

5 hours left

Open

New meetup

MY MEETUPS

MY GROUPS

<

## Suggest a meet

GROUP

Lithuanian Study Group

Climbing Group

TITLE

Bouldering

LOCATION

Vauxwall East

DATE

2026-06-10

TIME

14:00

Create

Meetups

Groups

Account



# Added voting on times

20:05

33

<

Suggest a meet

LOCATION optional

TenPin Bexleyheath

NOTES optional

Come at 6, we'll eat around 8

WHEN

Flexible

Fixed

Offer a time or two; people react and it locks at a deadline.

Tomorrow eve

This Sat

Sat eve

Next week

Thu, Jun 4

10:15 PM

+ Add a time

LOCKS IN

Locks Wed 3 Jun, 22:15

the evening before - best-supported time wins

Change

Float it

Add a title to continue

Meetups

Groups

Account

20:08

32

<

The Boys

LOCKS IN

11h 25m

best-supported time wins

Dancing

Which of these work?

Tap the times you can make - private to you.

☐ Wed 3 Jun, 19:00

☐ Sat 6 Jun, 13:00

+ Add a time

☐ I can't make it

you won't be asked again - tap a time to rejoin

Force lock now (dev)

Meetups

Groups

Account

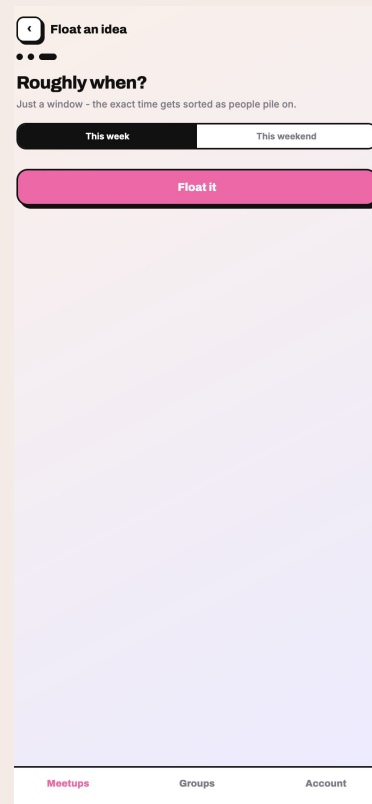
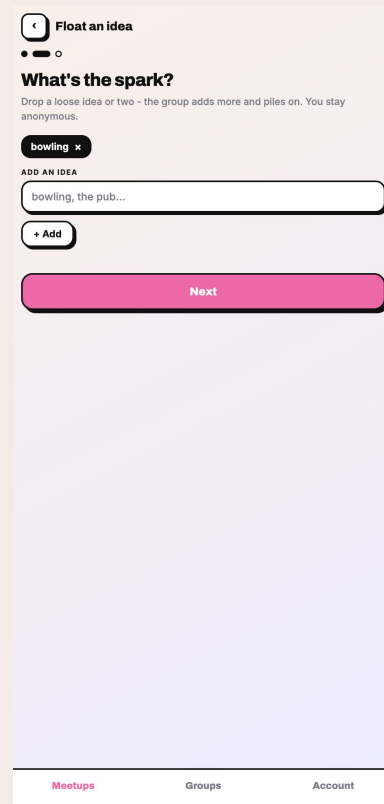
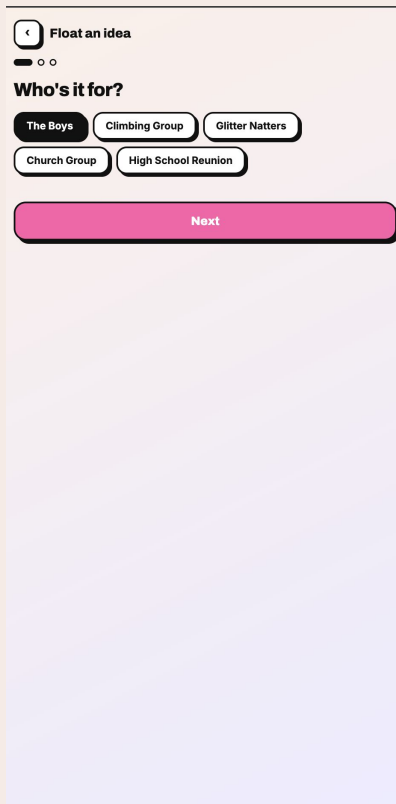
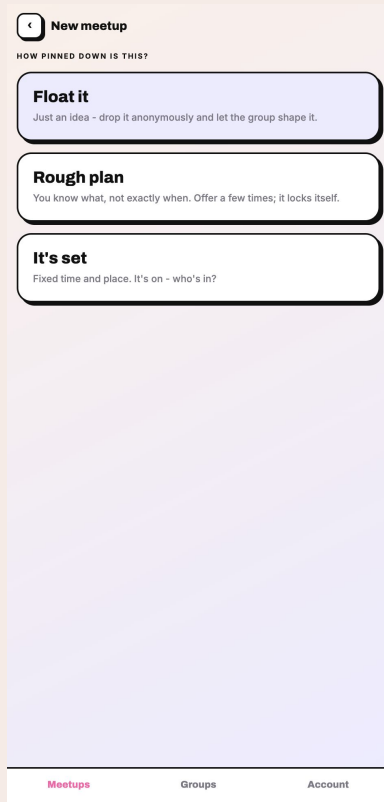


“This form feels  
quite cluttered”



“It takes me a second to read  
through to make sure I  
understand where to put  
everything”

# After some refinement





# User Story

**As a** new and introverted member of a friend group

**I want** to only attend social events if I already know people going

**So that** I feel comfortable



Core Interaction  
Conditional attendance

# Initial Mock-up

28th May 2026

Bowling

TenPin Bowling  
Bexleyheath  
16:00

I will make it

I won't make it

I will make it if...

|        |                                     |
|--------|-------------------------------------|
| Joe    | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Bethan | <input type="checkbox"/>            |
| Adi    | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Lily   | <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> |
| Nathan | <input type="checkbox"/>            |

are going

Confirm

Demonstration  
Conditional attendance

# User Story

**As** someone wanting to organise a meetup for my friends

**I don't want** to have to convince people to download a new app

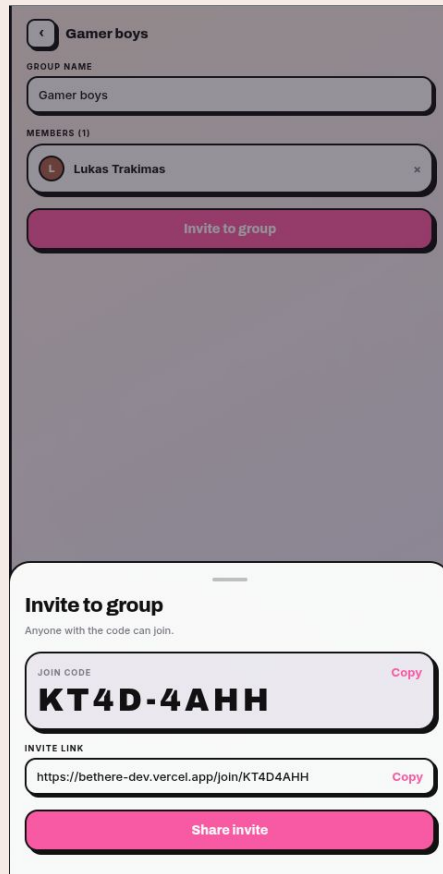
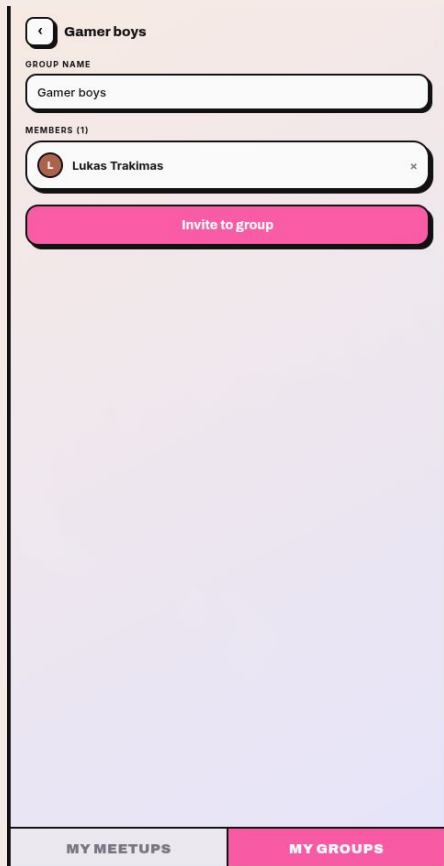
**So that** I can save time and avoid frustration





Core Interaction  
Onboarding new users

# Our Initial Design





# After some refinement

Meetup

VOTING CLOSES

5 days left

Top pick wins

The Boys

Edit

The Boys

What

+ add an activity

When

+ add a time

☐ Can't make it

Tap anything above to rejoin

No names, just the group.

Share this meetup

Anyone with the link can join and respond.

INVITE LINK

https://bethere-dev.vercel.app/m/e\_d63c1c81-e2d5-4ddd-at

Copy

Share invite

You're invited

TB

The Boys

Help pick a time

Join The Boys & respond

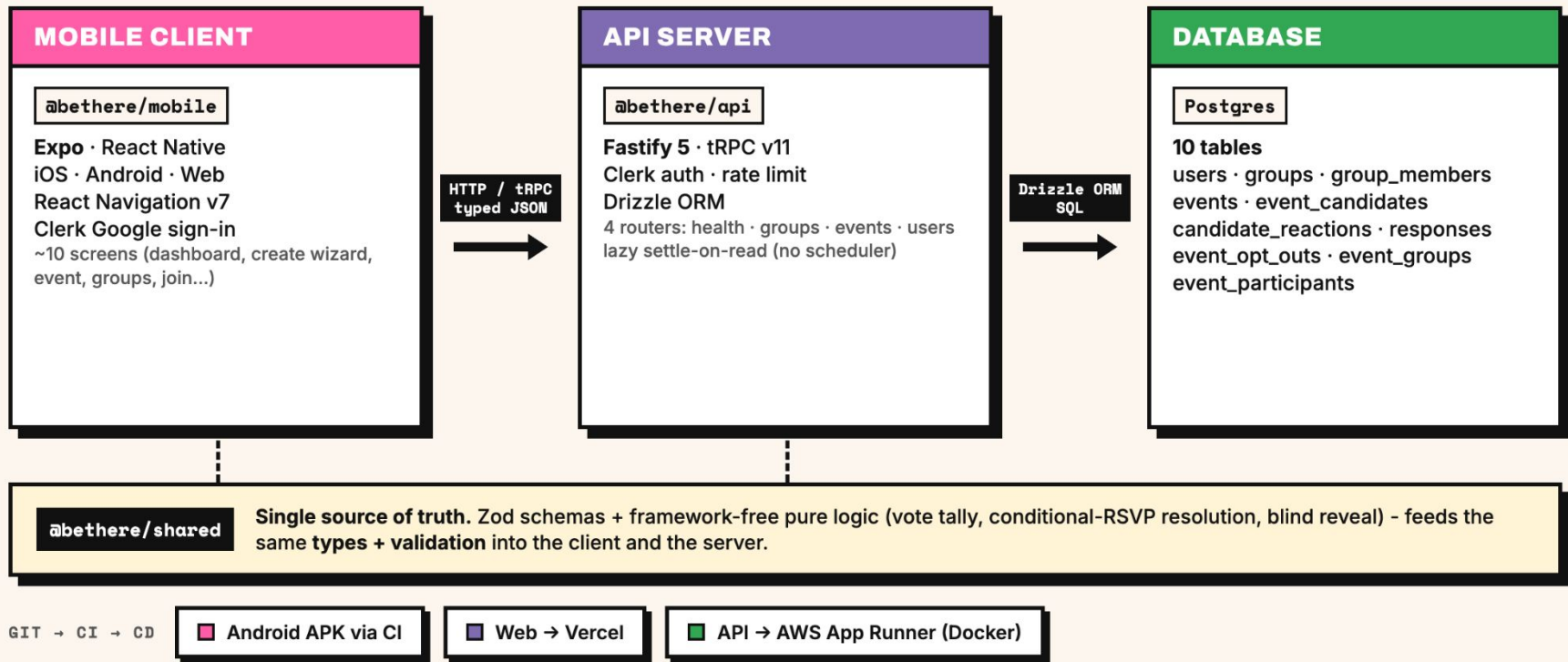
Continue as test user

No app to download.

Demonstration  
Onboarding new users

# Implementation

# System Architecture



# Why this **stack**

## TypeScript + pnpm monorepo

One language across client, server, and shared logic. Refactors are **type-checked end to end**.

## tRPC v11 + Zod

A **fully type-safe API** with zero hand-written types or codegen. One schema validates server input and types the client.

## Expo / React Native

One codebase ships to **iOS, Android, and web** - so we could test with real users on whatever device they already had.

## Fastify 5

A lightweight, fast Node server - a thin, low-overhead host for the tRPC layer.

## Postgres + Drizzle ORM

Groups, votes, and RSVPs are inherently relational, so the database gives us **integrity for free**, with typed SQL.

## Clerk

Managed auth with **real Google OAuth** - we don't roll our own identity or security.

## Git → GitHub Actions CI/CD

Lint, typecheck, and tests run on **every change**, with continuous deployment to AWS App Runner (API) and Vercel (web).



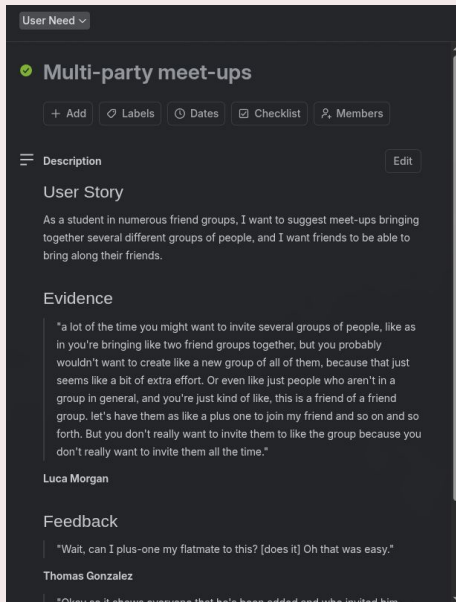
# Evaluation

# What Went Well

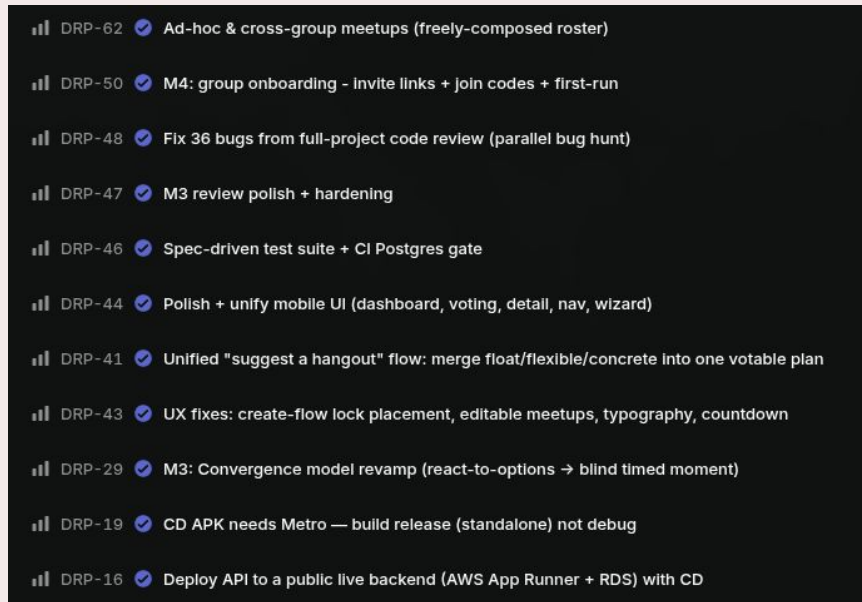
Continuous feedback from **new** and **recurring** users gave us diverse insights into how the problem is actually solved.

Letting users plan **real** meetups with their friends using BeThere helped identify the pain points of the app.

# Agile Development



**Trello** for mapping user needs.



**Linear** for engineering issues.

What We Would Do  
Differently

**Testing** : A stronger test suite with wider code coverage would've prevented bugs from recurring.

**Interviews:** .

Looking Ahead

Milly's availability may change  
after confirming she'll **BeThere** .

People who will go if Milly goes want to be  
notified she might not make it.



Plus-ones are still an awkward problem.

Vasanth may welcome plus-ones to his meetup, but there are some people he would prefer not to see there.

Meetup logistics are full of nuance,  
we cannot capture every case.

An in-app chat dedicated to the meetup,  
available after confirmation, would let the  
group settle the details.